

Lighting up the world

The invention of the electric light bulb lit up the world at night as never before. It paved the way for many other types of light and also brought electricity into people's homes for the first time. Electricity would soon power a wide range of domestic devices.



Moving lights

- **What?** Electric headlights
- **Who?** Electric Vehicle Company
- **Where and when?** US, 1898

Car headlights were originally fueled by oil or gas, which made them a fire risk. The first electric car headlights didn't work very well, because their filaments tended to burn out quickly. They also required their own supply of electricity, which made them expensive to run. Technology improved in the early 20th century and, in 1912, the American car company Cadillac came up with a method of powering headlights using the car's ignition system. Pictured above are the electric headlights of a Ford Model T from 1915.

► GLOWING LIGHTS

The colors of this neon sign in California are produced by different gases: neon for red, hydrogen for blue, helium for pink-orange, mercury for blue, and krypton for white-yellow. Since neon was the first gas to be used in this way, all gas-filled tubes that emit light are called neon lights.

FAST FACTS

- First switched on in 1901 and still burning to this day, the Centennial Light in Livermore, California, is the world's longest lasting light bulb.
- In 1881, London's Savoy Theatre became the first public building in the world to be lit entirely by electricity.
- On a clear night, the light on top of the Luxor Hotel in Las Vegas (right) is visible from more than 274 miles (440 km) away.
- The "World's Largest Light Bulb," on top of the Thomas Edison Memorial Tower in New Jersey, is actually now lit by LEDs.

Gas lights

- **What?** Neon lights
- **Who?** Georges Claude
- **Where and when?** France, 1910

The French physicist Georges Claude discovered that passing an electric current through a glass tube filled with neon gas produced an intense

orange light. The light wasn't bright enough to light up homes, but Claude thought it might work well as an advertising sign. In 1912, the first neon sign was switched on outside a barber shop in Paris. Neon advertisements were soon appearing around the world.

